

BUDGET PHONES

Increasingly inexpensive and convenient to own, everyone from your friendly neighbourhood fruit vendor to your bus driver—seem to be dancing to their own ring tones. The mobile phone is empowering the common man like no technology has done before.

This category is about phones for the masses, or in a word, affordable. Amongst the phones we tested, we classified those that fell below the Rs 5,500 price as Budget phones. Starting at about Rs 2,800, these humble gadgets do just what a phone is supposed to do—make and receive calls and exchange SMS. And, they do so with no fuss or frills.

As price is the major criterion in this category, let us break it further into three smaller price-bands and look at each group separately, to help simplify your choice.

Below Rs 3,000

In our test, the most inexpensive phones were the Motorola C139, the LG B2050 and the Nokia 2600 priced between the Rs 2,800 to Rs 3,000 range. The C139 could definitely use a better keypad and a more liberal spacing of keys: the cost of an affordable phone need not be sore fingers. The clarity of its tiny colour screen would have been acceptable a couple of years ago, but not today. A positive of this phone though, is its impressive battery life—450 hours of claimed standby time and 11.5 hours of talk time. Sur-

prising for a phone in its class, is that it allows you re-arrange its menu items. Life does offer small pleasures!

The LG B2050 shares the woes of the C139 when it comes to keypad feedback. However, the placement of the keys is well thought of, reducing the chances of pressing a wrong key. The screen is pleasant to see, as it is with most LG phones. The kill-joy, apart from the keypad is the slow response while composing messages. Considering that many buyers in this segment will be students with an SMS habit, this something that Motorola should look at.

In terms of usability, the LG phones are as friendly as their Nokia counterparts, as their menu system is inspired by the latter's. This makes the B2050 and the B2070 (reviewed in the next price-band) extremely easy to use, even for a first timer. Some LG uniqueness is maintained though: The right-navigation button in standby mode opens up a shortcut to inbox, voice mail, scheduler and alarm. Overall, the B2050 is an impressive phone.

The Nokia 2600 gives us very little to complain about—we could



LG B2050 - Looks cute, works without fuss

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